

do you guys end up ordering? Do you guys have the same thing?

Gayatri: Taste-wise, the only thing we try to avoid is sugar. But Treesa loves sushi, and I prefer eating Indian food these days. It wasn't always like this. Last year, I liked Japanese food, and Treesa would eat Indian food. But these days, I'm not so much into raw food.

Treesa: She's the one who changed my taste. She got me into Japanese food. Last year, she told me to try sushi, and I ended up liking it. But nowadays, she likes Indian food!

You play in different positions on the court (Gayatri at the net and Treesa towards the back), and you also seem to have very different personalities off it.

Gayatri: We have completely different personalities. Even our kit bags are different. Treesa collects so many keychains! She is also very outspoken. She can mingle with people very well. That's something very nice. I think I'm a little private. I feel it's a little better to keep it like that these days. I've always found it better to be alone. My Instagram is private because I don't like to have interactions with too many people. It's changing a little, and I think the BATC helped with that. I enjoyed being with friends and with the whole team.

You were part of a historic win at the Asia Team Championships. What does that do for you?

Treesa: We got a lot of confidence from how we played there. We played and won a few good matches. The match against the Japanese pair (current World No. 6 and former World No. 2 Nami Matsuyama and Chiharu Shida) was important. We were leading the third game 19-13, and then it became close — like 20-all. And it was tricky because both of us (India and Japan) were wondering which way it was going to go. The whole team was cheering for us. And in the end, we managed to get the win. When it's that close, there is a lot of pressure, especially when they made it 20-20. We just hung in and didn't make that many

errors. We just told each other, 'Don't make errors'.

Gayatri: I wasn't that confident before the tournament because I was coming back from an injury. We had played just a couple of tournaments before the BATC. Even against Japan and China, I didn't think we would win.

But it was different after we beat Japan. Compared to that match, I was much more confident against Thailand in the final, even though they were also higher ranked than us (Jongkolphan Kititharakul and Rawinda Prajongjai are currently World No. 10).

We had beaten these players before. Although we were confident, they also changed how they played against us. We were trailing in the third game, but once we caught up, the match changed very quickly in our favour.

You picked up three consecutive wins (they beat China's World No. 22 Li Yi Jing and Luo Xu Min in their opening match of the competition), and you also have many wins over higher-ranked players in the past year. At what point did you stop seeing these as upsets and just as regular wins?

Treesa: The confidence came at the 2022 All England (when they beat World No. 2 and reigning world silver medallists So-hee Lee and Shin Seung-chan). We have confidence that we can beat the top players in the world. But even now, we don't go in thinking we have to win. Gayatri always says, 'Go with the flow'. So we go with the flow, and even now, I think we are just chilling out on the court!

You've had a lot of good results over the years — the Commonwealth Games bronze, the runs at All England, and, of course, the BATC gold — where would you rate this?

Treesa: I think we place all of them on the same shelf. We played quite well during BATC. That gives us the confidence to play well in the coming tournaments. After the All England, both of us felt very motivated and confident that we could be among the best in the world. We are proud of the medal we have won.

Hopefully, we can get more medals and make India proud.

Part of what is fascinating about your partnership is that you only started playing together recently. Treesa has always been a strong doubles player, but Gayatri was a really strong singles player. Why did you decide to shift?

Gayatri: I love doubles. Even when I was a singles player, I had a passion for playing doubles. I love singles as well. But there's something about doubles that I like. During the [Covid-19] lockdown, me and my dad were sitting, and I thought maybe I should try playing this, and it just worked out very well. In the first few years, we were playing in the All-England semifinals, and we were getting to play the top players in the world. That was a really fast improvement. Playing (and beating) the Korean players changed everything. I was a lot more confident (about sticking to doubles) after that. I started playing it, thinking maybe this could be an option, but it worked out in my favour. So I'm happy.



“We don't specifically think about the Olympics. There's a lot of tournaments coming up. We know that if we play well, we could make it to the Olympics.”
— Treesa Jolly